



THE GUARDIANS OF ELARIA

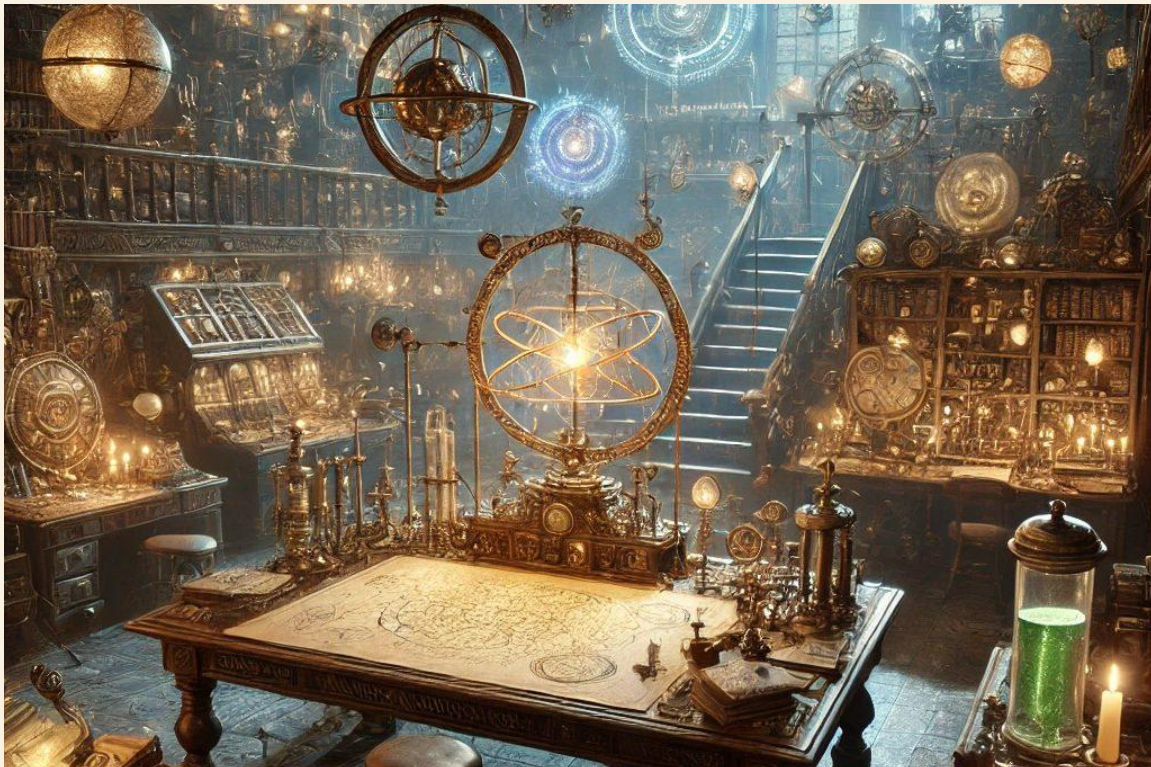
SESSION 3

The Quest for Knowledge

An illustrated adventure. Read the gold boxes aloud; the purple boxes are for the DM.

Previously, on The Guardians of Elaria...

In **Oakshade Village**, the missing herb gatherers wandered home dazed but safe the morning after the Mist Stalkers fell, and Elder Merwin paid his fifty gold with pride. On the road east the rival **Grimfang** goblins sprang their ambush and learned, loudly, why nobody ambushes Stabby Sharpblade twice. At the **Whispering Glade**, a sleeping goddess opened her eyes inside a vision: **Elaria**, her light fading, asking three young heroes for help, and leaving each of them a gift of her grace. The stone guardian **Terranox** tested their mettle and let them pass. And as the sun set over the cliffs, the party reached **Ravenstone Laboratory**, where the planar researcher **Professor Aelwyn Ravenstone** welcomed them among his impossible creatures and gave them warm beds for the night.



Ravenstone Laboratory in the morning light.

Part One: A Morning of Marvels

The heroes woke on their first morning at Ravenstone Laboratory, in a tower where magic and science share every shelf.

Morning sun filters through the high, arched windows of **Ravenstone Laboratory**, laying golden beams across tables cluttered with strange instruments and arcane diagrams. Soft, multicolored lights drift through the air, each one a captured mote of magical essence. Shelves climb the walls, crowded with ancient tomes, glowing crystals, and devices of intricate gears and shimmering runes. Small automatons scurry between the tables carrying tools, and somewhere below, one of the laboratory's remarkable creatures is snoring.

The Essence Sphere Under the Glass

Professor Aelwyn Ravenstone is already at his workbench, a delicate tool like a magnifying glass laced with arcane runes in one hand, and the **Essence Sphere** glowing gently before him. He has clearly been up since dawn. His silver hair glimmers in the sunlight, and his emerald eyes are wide with wonder.

Aelwyn: “By the Spheres! Even after a whole morning's study I can scarcely believe it. A fully functional Essence Sphere! Poots Glimmergear is a true genius of her craft. This device is beyond what I thought possible.”

Lilly, hovering at his elbow: “But can you help him? Pikachu is trapped in there. He needs a body again.”

Aelwyn turns the Sphere slowly, and the runes along his lens glow brighter. His face is kind, and honest, and that is exactly the problem: Lilly can read the answer in it before he speaks.

Aelwyn: “The energy within is stable, wonderfully stable. Your friend is safe. But there simply is not enough of it to weave him a body. I cannot do it here.” He raises a finger before Lilly's face can finish falling. “But there is hope. The

Artificer's Guild in **Gearhaven City** commands power core technology far beyond my little tower. Upgraded with a proper core, this Sphere could hold many essences at once, more than enough for your Pikachu to step back into the world.”



The Guardian of Balance

Aelwyn's gaze drifts to the little collection the party has gathered on their travels: faint captured orbs of water, air, and earth, each one humming softly in its jar.

Aelwyn: “These motes of yours are not stray magical oddities. They are fragments of planar essence, torn loose from their home realms. The balance of the planes is unraveling, and creatures are slipping through the cracks.”

Ursa, quietly: “We saw something on the road. A goddess, I think. Her name was Elaria. She said her power was fading, and that we needed to restore it.”

The professor goes very still. When he speaks again, the scientist's excitement is gone, and something older and graver has taken its place.

Aelwyn: “Elaria. The Guardian of Balance. Children, if *her* power is waning, then the boundaries between the planes will not merely leak. They will collapse. Everything you have seen, the motes, the strange creatures, the thin places in the forest, all of it is a world teetering on the brink.”

He crosses to a great ancient map on the wall, the realms of Elaria drawn in faded ink. Lines of light crisscross it like threads in a loom, and here and there a point pulses with unstable energy, like a fraying knot.

Aelwyn: “If you would restore the goddess, you will need more than courage. You will need knowledge, allies, and tools forged where magic and technology meet. The Artificer's Guild can upgrade your Sphere, yes. But its archives may also hold the secret of how to stitch a world back together.”



◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ The House of Ravenstone

The Ravenstones have studied the planes from their cliff for nine generations of high elves, which is to say about one generation of anyone else's family business. Their laboratory was built on the cliffs because, as the first Ravenstone wrote, the edge of the land is the best place to study the edges of everything else.

Part Two: Three Small Wonders

Before the road, the professor had one more gift to offer: a choice that would change the party forever.

As Aelwyn speaks, the laboratory's smallest residents come out to investigate the visitors. A leafy little dinosaur with a folded flower bud on its back lounges in a sunbeam by the window: a **Floraburst**. A round turtle-like creature wrapped in a shimmering watery aura waddles past, peering up curiously: an **Aqualump**. And a small fox-like creature with flames dancing harmlessly along its paws and tail darts between the table legs, chasing an automaton twice its size: an **Emberpaws**.

Aelwyn: “These little ones are manifestations of the unstable boundaries, each one carrying a fragment of elemental essence. They are not curiosities. They are clues. And they can sense planar anomalies long before you or I could.” He kneels among the three creatures and smiles. “Take one of them with you. Choose wisely; these little ones are eager to help, and one of them may be the key to understanding the forces that threaten our world.”

► **A real decision.** Let the players meet all three: Aqualump the sturdy shield, Emberpaws the bold striker, Floraburst the healer and scout. All three stat blocks are in the appendix; the two not chosen stay safe with Aelwyn.



The party crouches down and takes the choice seriously. Aqualump blows a solemn bubble and offers its shell for knocking. Emberpaws sets a very small patch of nothing important on fire, then looks proud. The little Floraburst watches from her sunbeam, quiet and green, her bud swaying like a tiny banner. The Guardians talk it over, weighing what the long road will need, and choose together: the leafy one. Lilly holds out her hand, and Floraburst rises, pads straight across the floor, and rests her head against Lilly's knee.

Lilly, softly: “Hello, Floraburst. Want to come save the world with us?”

► **Floraburst** joins the party (statistics in the appendix). She senses planar anomalies, produces healing Floraberries, and is, by unanimous ruling, a very good dinosaur.

A Farewell to Lickgloom

One companion arrives, and one stays behind. All morning **Lickgloom** has been everywhere at once: tasting beakers, startling automatons, trading tongue flicks with creatures no book has ever named. The little fey has not looked this happy since the night at the pond. Aelwyn watches it herd a family of glimmering hatchlings across the floor and chuckles.

Aelwyn: “You know, the road to Gearhaven is long, and a laboratory full of planar creatures could use a friendly guide who speaks their language. Lickgloom would have a home here. Friends here. And you would always know where to find it.”

The party gathers around their first friend of the wilds. Lickgloom tilts its head, looks once at the door and the long road beyond it, then at the warm, wonder-crowded laboratory, and a feeling arrives in everyone's minds at once, wordless and content: *Home. Friends. Visit?*

Ursa kneels and presses his forehead gently to Lickgloom's. “Visit. We promise. Every time we pass this way.” One long tongue wraps the whole party in a single ridiculous hug, and that is that. Guardians look after their friends, even when looking after them means letting them stay somewhere happy.



The Road to Gearhaven

Aelwyn unrolls a traveling map across the table, the parchment crackling, and traces the southward road with one slender finger.

Aelwyn: “First, **Brambleshadow Thicket**, a dense and thorny woodland of hidden pathways and mischievous fey. Stay alert; illusions are common there. Then **Whisperwind Meadow**, serene to look at, but the planar veil runs thin, and things from the Elemental Plane of Air sometimes wander through. Beyond that rise the **Ironroot Hills**, jagged rock and abandoned mines, home to creatures who do not take kindly to visitors. And at the last, **Stormwatch Cliffs**, where the lightning storms never quite end. Past the cliffs lies **Havenmoor**, a friendly coastal town. That will be your gateway to the seas: from Havenmoor you must take a ship onward toward Gearhaven.”

He rolls the map, ties it with a crimson ribbon, and presses it into their hands. Then he looks at each of them in turn. A hand on Lilly's shoulder: “Trust your bond with these magical creatures. Each step brings you closer.” A respectful nod to Ursa: “Your connection to the stars, and your father's legacy, will guide you through the unknown.” And a grin for Stabby: “Your spirit, wild and free, will cut through the chaos. Keep your blade sharp and your wit sharper.”

Aelwyn: “Go now, Guardians of Elaria. The road to Gearhaven awaits.”

With the map in hand, a leafy dinosaur trotting at their heels, and one last wave to a small fey creature in a laboratory window, the party steps out into the morning. The wind carries a whisper of adventure, and the promise of revelations to come.

Part Three: The Wild Road

The road south proved everything the professor promised: beautiful, strange, and increasingly full of teeth.

► **The road at a glance.** The journey runs about three days: Brambleshadow Thicket and Whisperwind Meadow the first day, the Mistwood Path and the climb into the Ironroot Hills the second, Stormwatch Cliffs and the descent to Havenmoor the third. The party camps twice along the way, so long rests, spell slots, and Floraberries reset between the hardest fights.

Shadowflame in Brambleshadow Thicket

Brambleshadow Thicket closes around the path like a dark, twisting tunnel. Gnarled branches knit overhead, thorny undergrowth crowds close, and shafts of pale sunlight struggle through the canopy. The air grows damp and cold, smelling of moss and something faintly metallic, like a storm that has not broken yet. Then, all at once, the birds stop singing.



The southward road disappears into Brambleshadow Thicket.

► Wisdom (Perception) DC 14 to notice the unnatural silence; Intelligence (Arcana) DC 15 to sense necrotic planar energy soaked into the shadows. If anyone succeeds, the party is on guard when the ambush comes; if every check fails, the Shadowflame strikes unseen and the heroes have disadvantage on their initiative rolls.

Ursa, whispering, his breath misting: “This does not feel right. Something is here. The forest itself feels sick.”

The mist thickens until the party can see barely twenty feet. The temperature plummets. A hollow laughter echoes through the trees, vibrating up through the ground, and from the swirling shadows two glowing eyes open. A twisted, flickering shape gathers itself out of dark purple flame: a **Shadowflame**, its jagged mouth curled into a grin, wisps of shadow trailing from its limbs like ghostly fire.

Shadowflame, in a whispery, disembodied voice: “Your fears are tasty... let me see them... let me taste them!”

► **The fight.** Shadowflame, CR 4 (appendix), in a 30-foot clearing walled by thorny brambles, the mist lightly obscuring everything: disadvantage on ranged attacks and on Perception by sight.

► **Illusions of Fear.** It opens by splitting into three identical illusions that move in step with it. Attacking one calls for Intelligence (Arcana) or Wisdom (Perception) DC 18 to pick the real flame; on a failure the blow passes through and the illusion remains, and an identified fake bursts into a swirl of shadow. The fakes cannot harm anyone: only the real flame attacks, which is itself a clue.

► **Round by round.** It stalks a vulnerable hero with Shadow Claw, saves Terror Wave (15-foot cone, Wisdom DC 14 or 3d10 necrotic and frightened) for when the party clusters, and Shadowmelds through the mist to reposition whenever it is cornered.

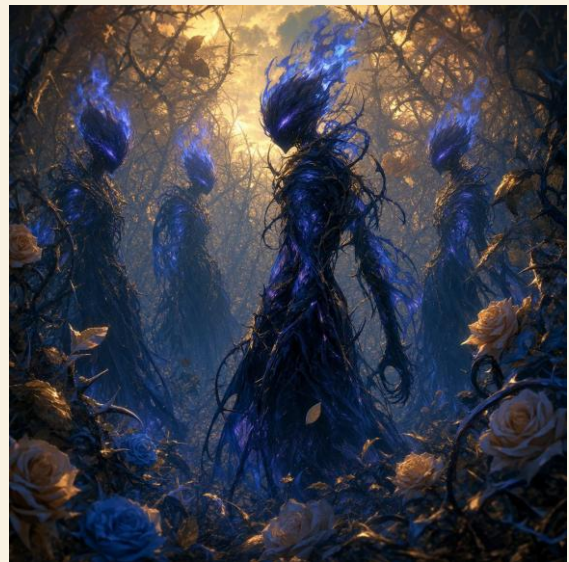
► **If the fight turns.** The Shadowflame feeds on fear, not flesh. If a hero drops, it lingers to savor the terror instead of pressing the attack, and it never pursues past the brambles: a party that runs escapes shaken but whole, and can circle back with a better plan for the illusions.

The clearing becomes a hall of dark mirrors. Four grinning shadows circle the party, moving as one, and blades pass through two of them before Lilly starts calling out which flame casts no light. Stabby is frightened for exactly one round, which he later denies. Floraburst's very first act as a companion is to snap a Razor Leaf through an illusion, and her second is to hit the real one. When the Shadowflame finally comes apart with a bone-chilling screech, the mist unravels with it.

Where it fell, a **Dark Mote** lingers, swirling with shadowy energy, pulsing faintly before it fades into the cold air. It does not feel like the others.

Ursa, shivering: “These motes... it is like each one is a piece of something much bigger.”

Lilly, watching the Essence Sphere stir faintly in response: “Then we keep collecting the pieces. For the world, and for Pikachu.” **Stabby**, grinning: “More shadows, more fights! We are going to need sharper swords!”



Whisperwind Meadow



Whisperwind Meadow, where the wind talks in its sleep.

Beyond the thicket the land opens into **Whisperwind Meadow**, and for one golden afternoon the road is kind. The grass runs in long silver waves, and the wind moving through it truly does whisper, half-words in no language anyone knows, as if the air itself is talking in its sleep. The veil is thin here; everyone can feel it, a hum behind the breastbone. But nothing wicked wanders through today. Floraburst dozes on Ursa's pack with her bud turned to the sun, and the Guardians let the meadow's strange lullaby carry them south.

The Talking Beasts of the Mistwood Path

Where the meadow meets the old forest, the trail dives into the **Mistwood Path**, and the fog comes back with a grudge. Twisted trees knit out the sun, the mist curls around ankles, and every footstep lands muffled, as if the forest is holding a pillow over the sound.

► Wisdom (Perception) DC 15: shapes flickering in the fog, pacing the party. Wisdom (Survival) DC 14: padded tracks that stop abruptly, mid-stride. Intelligence (Arcana) DC 16: planar distortion is warping the creatures here, granting them abilities they should not have. Any success means the party is braced when the ambush springs; if all three fail, the beasts strike from the fog first and the heroes have disadvantage on their initiative rolls.

Ursa, crouched over the tracks: “They just... stop. These creatures are moving in ways they should not be.”

A low growl rolls out of the fog, then a sharp whip-crack. Two **Displacer Beasts** flow out of the white: sleek, six-legged, black as spilled ink,



long barbed tentacles lashing over their shoulders. Their outlines shimmer and slide, each one standing a step to the left of wherever it actually is. And then comes the thing that makes the party's blood run colder than the fog. The beasts *speak*.

First beast, flickering in and out of sight: "Fresh prey... too easy." **Second beast**, tentacles lashing: "They will never see it coming."

Displacer beasts do not talk. Everyone knows displacer beasts do not talk. The fog suddenly feels less like weather and more like a doorway someone left open.

► **The fight.** Two displacer beasts (appendix) in a 40-foot clearing of fog, fallen logs, and roots: light obscurement, scattered cover, and difficult terrain. Displacement: attacks against each beast have disadvantage until it takes damage.

► **Tactics.** Hit-and-run: they lash from 10 feet with barbed tentacles, then slide back into the fog to flank and split the party. Ursa's Faerie Fire stripped the displacement trick away, and Stabby deflected a tentacle mid-swing to turn the tide.

► **If the fight turns.** The beasts are predators, not zealots: once one is reduced below half its hit points it slinks into the fog and does not return, and neither will leave the mist to chase a party that retreats to open ground.

When the beasts finally fall, their bodies shimmer and dissolve into wisps of mist, leaving only faint outlines on the ground. And beneath where they fell, strange runes lie etched into the forest floor, pulsing with a dark planar light.

► Intelligence (Arcana) DC 15: the runes are tears in the fabric of reality, seams where creatures from other planes seep into this one. On a failure the symbols stay a mystery for now; Aelwyn or the Guild's archives can explain them later.

Lilly, tracing the air above the runes: "These symbols are like cracks in a mirror. The boundaries between the planes are breaking down." **Ursa**: "Then worse things than talking cats are going to come through." **Stabby**: "Good thing we are here to stop them!"

The Shroomyte Grove

The path climbs into the **Ironroot Hills**, named for the iron-hard roots that twist through the earth like veins of metal. The higher the party climbs, the stranger the hills grow: bulbous mushrooms sprout between the rocks, their caps glowing with eerie blue-green light, until the whole hillside shines like a dream having a dream.

► Wisdom (Perception) DC 14: the ground pulses faintly; the roots shift. Intelligence (Arcana) DC 15: the mushrooms are suffused with Feywild energy, reacting to the party's presence. A success means the party enters the clearing ready for trouble; if both checks fail, the Shroomytes erupt from the soil with surprise on their side and the heroes have disadvantage on their initiative rolls.

Lilly, adjusting her goggles: "These mushrooms are not just glowing. They are responding to us. Be ready for anything." **Stabby**, twirling his sword: "Living mushrooms? Bet they are not ready for a good stabbing."



Glowing mushrooms light the climb into the Ironroot Hills.

The moment the party steps into a clearing ringed with glowing caps, the ground shudders. With a series of wet, tearing sounds, four **Shroomytes** pull themselves free of the soil, squat fungal bodies pulsing with inner light, tendrils of mycelium writhing like grasping fingers. A melodic hum rises from them, beautiful and menacing at once.

Shroomyte, in a vibrating, musical tone:
“Intruders... the grove... must be protected!”

► **The fight.** Four Shroomytes, CR 2 each (appendix), in a 40-foot clearing: dense mushroom clusters give half cover, 5-foot patches of damp, root-tangled ground are difficult terrain, and the caps' dim glow throws long, shifting shadows.

► **Tactics.** They open with Spore Blasts from range to poison and confuse, close in with Mycelium Tendrils to entangle and slow, then flank through the mushroom cover, one venting a spore cloud that obscures and poisons whoever stands in it. Lilly's fire found their weakness; Stabby simply refused to be caught.

► **If the fight turns.** The Shroomytes are guardians, not hunters: they defend the glowing clearing and never pursue beyond it. A party in trouble can withdraw and pick a longer path around the grove, losing an hour of climbing but nothing more.

It is a strange, glowing battle among the toadstools, and when the last Shroomyte folds gently back into the earth, the air fills with drifting, luminous spores, falling like warm snow. In the center of the clearing hovers a **Fungal Mote**, pulsing with otherworldly light.



Ursa, reaching toward it, its glow reflected in his eyes: “This one feels like the Feywild, bleeding into our world.” The Essence Sphere in Lilly’s pack hums in quiet agreement. The collection grows, and so does the mystery.

Part Four: Stormwatch Cliffs

By the time the hills gave way to open sky, the party could hear the sea, and the storm that lived above it.

Stormwatch Cliffs rise at the edge of the world: jagged stone ramparts above crashing waves, crowned with black clouds that flicker and grumble with lightning that never quite rests. The air crackles against the skin, tasting of salt and thunder. Etched into the rocks along the clifftop, strange runes glow with a pale blue light, brightening with every distant strike.

The Cliff Path

The only way forward is a narrow path snaking along the cliff’s edge, with sheer drops to the hungry ocean below. The wind shoves like a rude giant. Stone crumbles where stone should hold. The Guardians rope together, watch each other’s feet, and inch along the ledge while the storm booms overhead.

► **The cliff path skill challenge.** The narrow ledge: Dexterity (Acrobatics) DC 14; a slip means Strength (Athletics) DC 12 to catch the edge or take 1d6 bludgeoning from the fall. The crumbling section: Wisdom (Perception) DC 15 to spot it in time, or it collapses underfoot, Dexterity save DC 13 or 2d6 bludgeoning. The glowing runes: Intelligence (Arcana) DC 15 to recognize an ancient magical defense system guarding a hidden chamber, knowledge that pays off at the monolith (no harm on a failure; the monolith will introduce itself soon enough). Run the ledge as three obstacles in order; a hero who has already crossed can throw a rope back for advantage on a companion’s check.

The Monolith of Four Elements

Past the worst of the ledge, the path opens onto a circular stone platform carved into the cliffside. At its center stands a **monolith**, etched with the same runes as the cliffs, a lightning rod jutting from its peak. Every few minutes the storm reaches down and strikes the rod, and the whole platform glows. Around the monolith stand four smaller pedestals, each crowned with a rotating stone ring of symbols: **Air**, **Water**, **Earth**, and **Fire**.

Etched into the monolith’s base, half-worn by centuries of storms, four phrases: *The winds whisper first. The tide rises after. Stone stands firm next. Flame seals the fate.*

◆ THE LIGHTNING PUZZLE OF STORMWATCH CLIFFS ◆

Four pedestals, four elements, one storm that never rests. The monolith opens only for those who read the cliffs' riddle and dare the lightning's timing.

The pieces. Each of the four pedestals carries a rotating stone ring of element symbols: **Air, Water, Earth, Fire**. The monolith's lightning rod takes a strike every few minutes, and the runes along the cliffs pulse with each one.

The riddle. Four phrases are carved into the monolith's base: *The winds whisper first. The tide rises after. Stone stands firm next. Flame seals the fate.*

Reading it. Intelligence (Investigation) or Wisdom (Insight) DC 15 to deduce the sequence from the clues: **Air, then Water, then Earth, then Fire**. Intelligence (Arcana) DC 16 to realize the alignment must be finished **as the lightning strikes the rod**, not before, not after.

The stakes. A wrong alignment when the bolt lands discharges wild energy: 2d6 lightning to everyone standing near the monolith. The right alignment on the storm's next breath, and the monolith drinks the bolt whole.

Hints, from gentle to loud. If the table stalls: first, the four phrases are carved top to bottom, in order. Second, after any wrong strike, the Air pedestal's rune alone stays lit a heartbeat longer than the rest: first in line. Third, Floraburst pads to the correct next pedestal and sneezes at it.

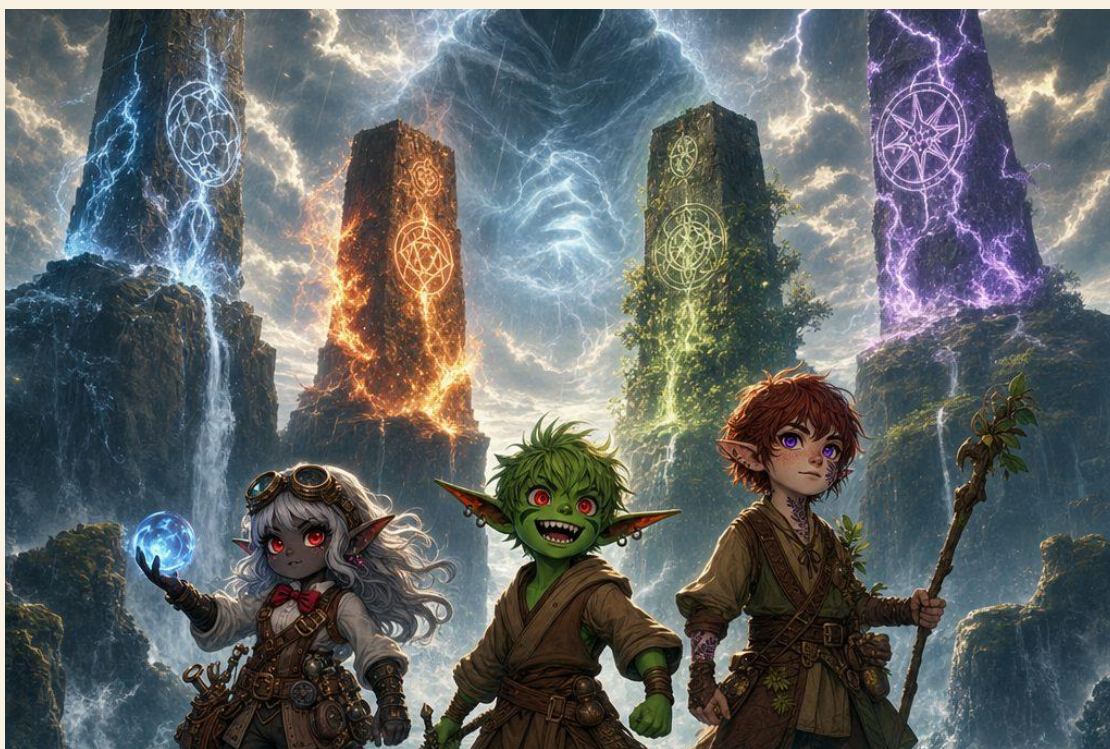
No dead ends. The monolith resets with every strike, so trial and error always works eventually; it just costs 2d6 lightning per wrong guess. Heroes who read the cliff runes on the way up already know the system rewards precision, and may take the Arcana timing check with advantage.

Stone rings grind into place: wind, tide, stone, flame. The storm inhales. Lightning hammers the rod, and this time the monolith drinks it, humming louder and louder until a beam of pure light lances up into the clouds and blooms into a shimmering curtain of energy above the platform.

The Dark Figure

Within the curtain of light, a vision takes shape: a towering figure cloaked in darkness, its face hidden, its presence pressing down on the platform like a cold hand. The storm itself seems to lean away from it. When it speaks, the voice does not come through the air. It arrives directly inside their minds.

The dark figure: “You meddle with forces beyond your comprehension. The boundaries between realms are mine to shatter and shape. The goddess's light fades, and chaos will reign. The motes you gather are but embers of a dying flame. You cannot stop the unraveling.”



The dark figure appears above the monolith at Stormwatch Cliffs.

The vision collapses into darkness, and the light curtain blows out like a candle. Where it stood, something small falls to the stone with a crystalline chime: a **Dark Fragment**, a shard of crystallized energy swirling with elemental chaos, cold to the touch and heavier than it looks.

► Intelligence (Arcana) DC 15: the fragment is a remnant of the same power corrupting the planar boundaries, tied directly to the weakening of Elaria. On a failure the shard keeps its secret for now; the Artificer's Guild can identify it later. Either way the party keeps it, carefully wrapped.

Until this moment, the breaking of the world might have been an accident: a storm, a sickness, a slow unlucky fraying. No longer. Someone stood in that light and called the boundaries *mine*. Someone is doing this on purpose.

Ursa: “That figure... they want to unravel everything. We have to stop them.” **Lilly:** “The Artificer's Guild might be our best chance to figure this out, and to bring Pikachu back.”

Stabby: “Whoever they are, they are going to get a taste of my blade!”

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ The Weaver of Fractures

Maldrith did not hate the world. The old verses are careful about this. She was hunger given patience, a thing from beyond the walls that wanted in, and the walls, being made of starlight, could only hold if someone kept the stars lit.

Part Five: The Lights of Havenmoor

The storm broke behind them, and the path wound down from the cliffs toward the glow of a town that smelled like cookies.

As the party descends, the roar of the sea softens, and new sounds drift up to meet them: distant laughter, jingling bells, a thread of festive music. The path becomes a cobblestone road flanked by frost-dusted pines, and the cold air fills with the mingled scents of sea salt, pine needles, cinnamon, nutmeg, and fresh-baked cookies.



Havenmoor at dusk, every window aglow.

Ahead at dusk lies **Havenmoor**, a coastal town sprung whole from a holiday fairytale. Stone and timber houses wear wreaths and garlands and twinkling lights. Red ribbons wrap the lamp posts, snow dusts the rooftops, and warm hearth-glow spills out of every window onto the cobbles. In the town square towers the **Great Pine of Havenmoor**, its branches heavy with glass baubles and shimmering ribbons, enchanted lights flickering among the boughs, a golden star burning at its top. Children pelt each other with snowballs beneath it. A painted signpost reads: *Welcome to Havenmoor! May your hearts be warm and your spirits bright!* A small figure comes bustling up, barely three feet tall, in a green tunic, red-striped leggings, and a pointed red hat tipped with a jingle bell. His cheeks are rosy and his grin is enormous.

Festive elf: “Ho there, travelers! Welcome to Havenmoor, where the chill may bite, but the cheer warms all! You must be weary after your journey. Come, come! The Sugarplum Hearth awaits: hot cocoa, cookies, and a warm fire!”

The Sugarplum Hearth

The **Sugarplum Hearth** is a cozy two-story tavern with a thatched roof, holly on the door, and a wooden sign bearing a steaming mug and a sugarplum. Inside, a hearth roars beneath a mantel hung with stockings, an enchanted harp plays softly in the corner, and every table carries frosted cookies, peppermint bark, and mugs of hot cocoa crowned with whipped cream. Floraburst is an immediate celebrity; three children and one grandmother declare her the best dinosaur they have ever met.

Greta Frostbough, the tavern keeper, a stout dwarf woman with silver hair and a warm smile, appears with extra marshmallows unasked. “A bit of sweetness warms the soul, do you not think? You lot look like you have seen some excitement. Tell me, what brings you to Havenmoor?”

By the fire, **Elda Merrywhistle**, a half-elf storyteller with a lute, spins tales for a knot of wide-eyed children. Between songs she leans toward the party, and her voice drops low. “They say the sea has been restless of late. Ships vanish in the fog, and lights dance on the waves. If you are setting sail, beware the spirits of the deep.”

Night settles over Havenmoor like a quilt. The party is given warm rooms upstairs, feather beds and thick blankets, each window overlooking the softly glittering square. In the morning, they are promised, **Master Bramblebeard** the shipwright will come by to talk of passage north. Below the window, the Great Pine glows on through the dark: a small, stubborn light against a gathering storm, which is, after all, exactly what Guardians are.

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ The First Star Out

Beltegeuse went dark on a clear night, with half the Circle watching. The records of that night are strange to read: forty sky-readers, and not one of them wrote the word “impossible,” because every one of them had been trained by the list of names to know exactly what it meant.



Their third adventure was done: a professor's warning, a leafy new companion, a farewell to a fey friend, four battles on the wild road, and a shadowy figure who wanted the world's walls broken. The Guardians of Elaria slept warm in Havenmoor, and did not yet know how much this bright little town was about to need them.

► After this session the heroes reached **level 4**.

Next: Session 4, in which Havenmoor's festive lights flicker, a horned shadow comes creeping for the children of the town, and eight winter bells hold the key to driving it back into the dark.

APPENDIX

DM Run Sheet: The Session at a Glance

Every DC, dial, and spotlight, in play order. Keep this page at your elbow.

The Shape of the Session

Five parts, three fights, two camps. P1 Ravenstone morning: the Sphere verdict (Pikachu needs a Gearhaven power core) and the Guardian of Balance reveal. P2 the companion choice (Floraburst joins), the Lickgloom farewell, the route briefing. P3 the wild road, three days: FIGHT 1 Brambleshadow Thicket (Shadowflame, then the Dark Mote), the Whisperwind breather, camp; FIGHT 2 the Mistwood Path (talking Displacer Beasts, then the planar runes), FIGHT 3 the Shroomyte Grove (Fungal Mote), camp. P4 Stormwatch Cliffs: the ledge skill challenge, the lightning puzzle, the dark figure and the Dark Fragment. P5 Havenmoor at dusk: the Sugarplum Hearth, sea rumors, warm beds, LEVEL 4.

Fights at a Glance

FIGHT 1: The Shadowflame (Hard; it feeds on fear, not flesh, so a drop is survivable). 1x Shadowflame (AC 14, HP 58, fly 40 hover; opens by splitting into THREE illusions, DC 18 Arcana or Perception to pick the real flame, only the real one attacks; Terror Wave rech 5-6: 15-ft cone, DC 14 Wis, 3d10 necrotic + frightened; Shadowmeld reaction: teleports 20 ft when hit). Mist lightly obscures the 30-ft clearing: disadvantage on ranged attacks and sight Perception. Scout it: Perception DC 14 (the birds stop) or Arcana DC 15 (necrotic shadows); every check failed = it strikes unseen, disadvantage on initiative. The out: it never pursues past the brambles; a party that runs can circle back with a plan.

FIGHT 2: The Mistwood Beasts (Hard; they TALK, and that wrongness is the real clue). 2x Displacer Beast (AC 13, HP 85; Displacement: attacks against it have disadvantage until it takes damage, Faerie Fire strips the trick; 2x Tentacle +6, reach 10 ft, 1d6+4 plus 1d8 force). Fog, fallen logs, difficult terrain; hit-and-run flanking. Scout it: Perception DC 15 (shapes pacing the party), Survival DC 14 (tracks that stop mid-stride), or Arcana DC 16 (planar warp); all three fail = ambush from the fog + disadvantage on initiative. After: Arcana DC 15 reads the runes beneath the bodies as tears in reality. The out: below half HP a beast slinks into the fog for good, and neither will chase the party onto open ground.

FIGHT 3: The Shroomyte Grove (Medium; guardians, not hunters). 4x Shroomyte (AC 13, HP 27; Spore Blast +4, range 30 ft, 2d6+2 poison, DC 13 Con or poisoned; Mycelium Tendrils restrain, DC 13 Str; Fungal Retribution reaction: melee attackers take 2d4 poison, DC 13 Con negates). Mushroom clusters give half cover; damp root patches are difficult terrain. Fire is the discovery. Scout it: Perception DC 14 (the ground pulses) or Arcana DC 15 (Feywild energy); both fail = they erupt with surprise + disadvantage on initiative. The out: they never leave the glowing clearing; circling the grove costs one hour.

The Resource Picture

A three-day road with two camps: long rests land after the Thicket and after the Hills, so every fight starts near full. The real spend is day two, the Mistwood and the Grove back to back on one camp's

resources. Floraburst brings the party's first pocket healing: 1d4+1 Floraberries 3/day, a Bonus Action to eat (2024 Goodberry rule), 3 HP each. The cliffs are the other tax, run as three obstacles in order: the ledge (Acrobatics DC 14; a slip is Athletics DC 12 or 1d6), the crumbling section (Perception DC 15, or Dex save DC 13 for 2d6), and the runes (Arcana DC 15, pays off at the monolith). The puzzle: Investigation or Insight DC 15 reads the riddle's order (Air, Water, Earth, Fire), Arcana DC 16 nails the lightning timing, and every wrong strike costs 2d6 lightning; a rope thrown back across the ledge gives a companion advantage. The party sleeps in Havenmoor at **level 4**.

Spotlights & Seeds

Lilly: the Sphere verdict lands on her, and turns grief into a destination: the Artificer's Guild can bring Pikachu back (Door: Gearhaven) → calls the real Shadowflame by the light it does not cast → reads the mirror-crack runes on the Mistwood floor → her fire finds the Shroomytes' weakness → “we keep collecting the pieces.”

Stabby: loudly unafraid (frightened exactly one round, later denied) → deflects a tentacle mid-swing to turn the Mistwood fight → refuses to be caught by a single tendril in the grove → “they are going to get a taste of my blade!” (Seed: the dark figure just made Stabby's list.)

Ursa: feels the sick forest before every ambush, his senses lead the road → Faerie Fire strips the beasts' Displacement → reads every mote (“pieces of something much bigger”) → Aelwyn's charge: your connection to the stars, and your father's legacy, will guide you (Door: the father's trail).

Foreshadow Tracker: say it, then say it again

The tells, in order. Aelwyn's wall map: points of unstable energy pulsing like fraying knots, say it before the road proves it • the Dark Mote “does not feel like the others” → the Dark Fragment at the cliffs → someone stood in that light and called the boundaries MINE • displacer beasts DO NOT TALK: the fog is a doorway someone left open • the cliff runes reward Arcana on the way up (advantage at the monolith) • the veil hums thin over Whisperwind Meadow: even the gentle stretch is a doorway • Aelwyn: the Guild's archives may hold the secret of stitching a world back together (the Gearhaven arc) • Elda Merrywhistle: restless seas, vanishing ships, lights on the waves (the voyage ahead) • the Great Pine glowing against a gathering storm: Havenmoor will need its Guardians soon.

APPENDIX

Bestiary: Enemy Stat Blocks

All three encounters of Session 3, in the order the party meets them, plus the professor's three companions.

ENEMIES, Fight 1: The Shadowflame

Brambleshadow Thicket • Difficulty: Hard • 1× Shadowflame

SHADOWFLAME

Medium undead, chaotic evil • CR 4 • fights alone

AC 14 (natural armor) **HP** 58 (9d8+18) **Speed** 0 ft, fly 40 ft (hover)

STR 8 **DEX** 18 **CON** 14 **INT** 12 **WIS** 15 **CHA** 18

Skills Stealth +8, Intimidation +6

Resist acid, fire, lightning, necrotic; nonmagical piercing & bludgeoning

Imm. poison, psychic; (cond) charmed, frightened, grappled, paralyzed, poisoned, prone, restrained

Senses darkvision 60 ft

Traits

Illusions of Fear. Creates three identical illusions of itself (AC 14) that move in step with it. DC 18 Arcana or Perception to spot a fake, or the attack misses and the illusion remains. The fakes cannot harm anyone; only the real flame attacks, which is itself a clue.

Actions

Shadow Claw. +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. Hit: 2d8+4 necrotic, and the target makes a DC 14 Wisdom save or is frightened one turn.

Terror Wave (Recharge 5-6). 15-ft cone, DC 14 Wisdom save; 3d10 necrotic and frightened 1 minute (repeat the save at the end of each turn).

Reactions

Shadowmeld. When hit, teleports up to 20 ft and becomes lightly obscured.



Tactics: It stalks a vulnerable hero with Shadow Claw, saves Terror Wave for when the party clusters, and Shadowmelds through the mist whenever it is cornered. It feeds on fear, not flesh: if a hero drops, it lingers to savor the terror instead of pressing the attack, and it never pursues past the brambles.

ENEMIES, Fight 2: The Talking Beasts

The Mistwood Path • Difficulty: Hard • 2× Displacer Beast

DISPLACER BEAST

Large monstrosity, unaligned • CR 3 • ×2

AC 13 (natural armor) **HP** 85 (10d10+30) **Speed** 40 ft

STR 18 **DEX** 15 **CON** 16 **INT** 6 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 8

Senses darkvision 60 ft

Traits

Displacement. Projects an illusion of standing beside itself; attack rolls against it have disadvantage until it takes damage. Faerie Fire strips the trick away entirely.

Planar Warp. These beasts speak, which displacer beasts never do: the planar distortion here is granting creatures abilities they should not have.

Actions

Multiattack. Two Tentacle attacks.

Tentacle. +6 to hit, reach 10 ft. Hit: 1d6+4 bludgeoning plus 1d8 force.



Tactics: *Hit-and-run: they lash from 10 feet with barbed tentacles, then slide back into the fog to flank and split the party. Predators, not zealots: once one is reduced below half its hit points it slinks into the fog and does not return, and neither will leave the mist to chase a party on open ground.*

ENEMIES, Fight 3: The Shroomyte Grove

The Ironroot Hills • Difficulty: Medium • 4× Shroomyte

SHROOMYTE

Small plant, neutral • CR 2 • ×4

AC 13 (natural armor) **HP** 27 (5d8+5) **Speed** 20 ft

STR 12 **DEX** 12 **CON** 14 **INT** 6 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 7

Saves Con +4, Wis +3 **Skills** Stealth +3, Perception +3

Resist poison **Imm.** (cond) poisoned

Senses darkvision 60 ft **Languages** understands Sylvan

Traits

Bioluminescent Glow. Sheds dim light in a 10-ft radius; can suppress it as a bonus action.

Actions

Multiattack. One Spore Blast and one Mycelium Tendrils.

Spore Blast. +4 to hit, range 30 ft. Hit: 2d6+2 poison, and the target makes a DC 13 Constitution save or is poisoned one turn.

Mycelium Tendrils. +4 to hit, reach 10 ft. Hit: 2d4+2 bludgeoning, and the target makes a DC 13 Strength save or is restrained one turn.

Reactions

Fungal Retribution. A melee attacker within 5 ft takes 2d4 poison (DC 13 Constitution negates).



Tactics: They open with Spore Blasts from range to poison and confuse, close in with Mycelium Tendrils to entangle, then flank through the mushroom cover, one venting a spore cloud that obscures and poisons whoever stands in it. Fire finds their weakness. Guardians, not hunters: they defend the glowing clearing and never pursue beyond it.

ALLIES: The Companion Choice

Ravenstone Laboratory • Aelwyn's three little wonders • the party chose Floraburst

FLORABURST

Small fey, neutral good • the party's companion

AC 14 (natural armor) **HP** 45 (6d6+18) **Speed** 30 ft

STR 14 **DEX** 12 **CON** 16 **INT** 10 **WIS** 14 **CHA** 10

Skills Nature +4, Survival +4 **Resist** poison

Senses darkvision 60 ft **Languages** understands Sylvan and Common but cannot speak

Traits

Anomaly Sense. Senses planar anomalies long before anyone else could; the healer and scout of the professor's three.

Plant Camouflage. Advantage on Stealth checks to hide in heavy foliage.

Photosynthesis. Recovers an additional 10 HP when resting in sunlight.

Actions

Razor Leaf. +4 to hit, range 30 ft. Hit: 2d8+2 slashing.

Vine Lash. +4 to hit, reach 15 ft. Hit: 1d10+2 bludgeoning, and the target makes a DC 13 Strength save or is restrained one turn.

Floraberry (3/Day). Produces 1d4+1 magical berries; eating one is a Bonus Action (2024 Goodberry rule) and restores 3 HP.



AQUALUMP

Small water elemental, neutral good • stayed with Aelwyn



AC 16 (natural armor, shell) **HP** 54 (7d6+21)

Speed 25 ft, swim 30 ft

Skills Athletics +4, Perception +3 **Resist** cold

Senses darkvision 60 ft **Languages** understands Aquan and Common

Traits

Shell Defense. Bonus action: withdraws into its shell, +4 AC until the start of its next turn, speed 0 while inside.

Water Veil. Cannot be set on fire; advantage on saves against being ignited or burned.

Actions

Water Bolt. +4 to hit, range 30 ft. Hit: 2d8+2 bludgeoning, and the target makes a DC 14 Strength save or is knocked prone.

Surf (Recharge 5-6). 15-ft cone of water, DC 14 Dexterity save; 4d6 cold (half on a success) and knocked prone on a failure.

Frost Shell. +4 to hit, range 20 ft. Hit: 1d10+2 cold, and the target's speed drops 10 ft until the end of its next turn.

EMBERPAWS

Small fire elemental, chaotic good • stayed with Aelwyn



AC 15 (natural armor) **HP** 42 (6d6+15)

Speed 30 ft

Skills Acrobatics +5, Perception +3 **Imm.** fire

Senses darkvision 60 ft **Languages** understands Ignan and Common

Traits

Fiery Spirit. At 0 HP it can burst into flame: each creature within 10 ft makes a DC 13 Dexterity save, taking 2d6 fire on a failure, half on a success.

Heatwave (3/Day). Bonus action: radiates intense heat for 1 minute; any creature that hits it with a melee attack takes 1d8 fire.

Actions

Ember. +5 to hit, range 30 ft. Hit: 2d6+2 fire.

Bite. +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. Hit: 1d8+3 piercing.

Tail Flame Whip. +5 to hit, reach 10 ft. Hit: 2d6+3 fire, and the target makes a DC 13 Dexterity save or is ignited (1d4 fire at the start of each of its turns until someone uses an action to douse it).

Tactics: A real decision, so let the players meet all three: Aqualump the sturdy shield, Emberpaws the bold striker, Floraburst the healer and scout. The party talked it over, weighed what the long road would need, and chose together; the two not chosen stay safe with Aelwyn.